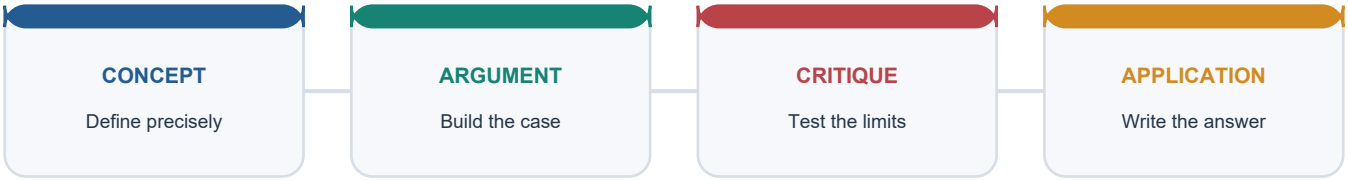
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

The Khaljis: Alauddin Khalji & Market Reforms - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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The Khaljis: Alauddin Khalji & Market Reforms - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Workbook MCQ 01

Question: Which statement best expresses the repository's framing of the Khalji period?

- A. It is best read through source criticism and state-capacity analysis.
- B. It should be described chiefly as a medieval socialist experiment.
- C. It is mainly a romance about Padmavati.
- D. It has no meaningful continuity with the Mamluk period.

Answer: A - It is best read through source criticism and state-capacity analysis.

- A. **Correct.** Correct. This topic reads Alauddin's reign through named-source criticism (Barani, Khusrau, Isami) combined with an analysis of what a Delhi-centred medieval state could actually enforce.
- B. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. "Socialist" imports a nineteenth/twentieth-century redistributive ideology onto a coercive military-fiscal regime aimed at army affordability, not consumer equality.
- C. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Padmavati belongs to Jaisi's sixteenth-century Padmavat tradition, a separate literary-memory question from the political-economic framing this topic teaches.
- D. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Delhi, iqta logic and court routines carried over from the Mamluks into the Khalji period; institutional continuity, not rupture, is the safer baseline.

Trap: Treating the topic as an ideological label (socialist, communal, purely literary) instead of a source-critical, state-capacity analysis.

Workbook MCQ 02

Question: The "Khalji revolution" most safely refers to:

- A. the immediate annexation of the whole Deccan
- B. the widening of the ruling class beyond the old Turkish monopoly
- C. the abolition of iqta assignments
- D. the replacement of all nobles by village headmen

Answer: B - the widening of the ruling class beyond the old Turkish monopoly

- A. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Deccan annexation was gradual and mostly post-Khalji; 1290 changed who could hold high office in Delhi, not the empire's southern boundary.
- B. **Correct.** Correct. Jalaluddin's 1290 accession broke the old Turkish nobility's monopoly of the throne and high office, which is the phrase's safest meaning.
- C. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Iqta assignments continued as the Sultanate's basic fiscal-military mechanism throughout the Khalji period; they were not abolished in 1290.
- D. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Village headmen (muqaddams) were themselves later targeted for reduced privileges under Alauddin; they never replaced the Delhi nobility.

Trap: Inflating a change in elite composition into a change in land tenure, provincial boundaries or rural administration.

Workbook MCQ 03

Question: Jalaluddin Khalji's political style is best described as:

- A. pure military despotism without any conciliatory element
- B. identical to Alauddin's confiscatory style
- C. comparatively tolerant and support-oriented by Sultanate standards
- D. based on abolishing the army's frontier role

Answer: C - comparatively tolerant and support-oriented by Sultanate standards

- A. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. The sources credit Jalaluddin with softer, consent-seeking rhetoric, which "pure despotism" directly contradicts.
- B. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. The whole point of the Jalaluddin-Alauddin contrast is that Alauddin's surveillance and confiscation were a harder departure from Jalaluddin's relative leniency.
- C. **Correct.** Correct. Jalaluddin is remembered as the first Sultan to argue for rule resting on the willing support of the governed, a comparatively conciliatory stance for the period.
- D. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Jalaluddin remained an active frontier commander against Mongol pressure; conciliation in domestic policy did not mean abandoning frontier defence.

Trap: Assuming every Delhi Sultan governed with identical harshness, erasing the deliberate Jalaluddin-Alauddin contrast the sources draw.

Workbook MCQ 04

Question: Alauddin's road to power in 1296 pivoted on:

- A. his architectural patronage at Siri
- B. a village assembly election at Kara
- C. a caliphal nomination received in Delhi
- D. the Devagiri loot, the Kara meeting and the murder of Jalaluddin

Answer: D - the Devagiri loot, the Kara meeting and the murder of Jalaluddin

- A. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Siri was built later, after Alauddin was already Sultan and facing Mongol pressure; it played no part in the 1296 succession.
- B. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. No village-assembly election mechanism existed in the Delhi Sultanate; succession here was decided by wealth, murder and elite coalition-building.
- C. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Caliphal recognition, where claimed, was a legitimising afterthought for Delhi Sultans, not the operative mechanism of Alauddin's own 1296 seizure.
- D. **Correct.** Correct. Devagiri's loot funded Alauddin's bid, the Kara meeting was where he had Jalaluddin killed, and both together explain his subsequent legitimacy problem.

Trap: Looking for a formal, lawful succession mechanism where the actual process was wealth, assassination and coerced recognition.

Workbook MCQ 05

Question: In Topic 04's political-geography language, the Delhi-Siri-upper doab belt is:

- A. the core enforcement and provisioning zone
- B. a distant tribute zone
- C. a purely literary construction of Barani
- D. only a symbolic ceremonial landscape

Answer: A - the core enforcement and provisioning zone

- A. **Correct.** Correct. Revenue reform, market regulation, army pay and urban provisioning were all deepest in Delhi-Siri and the upper doab, making it the topic's core zone.

- B. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Tribute zones (Rajasthan, parts of the Deccan) sit further out on the political-geography scale; the doab was directly taxed, not merely tribute-paying.
- C. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. While Barani is the main source for the doab's fiscal regime, the region's khalisa status and measurement-based revenue are treated as historically real, not literary invention.
- D. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. The zone's significance is fiscal and military (revenue, grain, army pay), not primarily ceremonial or symbolic.

Trap: Confusing the most heavily taxed and enforced zone with a merely tributary or symbolic one.

Workbook MCQ 06

Question: The 1303 Mongol episode is most closely linked with:

- A. the fall of Warangal
- B. the fortification of the defended Siri position near Delhi
- C. the capture of Siwistan
- D. the treaty with Ramachandra of Devagiri

Answer: B - the fortification of the defended Siri position near Delhi

- A. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Warangal belongs to the later Deccan campaigns under Malik Kafur (1306-11), a different theatre and years from the 1303 Mongol crisis.
- B. **Correct.** Correct. Targhi's 1303 pressure on Delhi coincided with Alauddin's return from Chittor and is anchored to the defended Siri-Delhi position.
- C. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Siwistan's capture and recovery (Zafar Khan) belongs to 1298, five years before the Targhi crisis.
- D. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Ramachandra's submission belongs to the Deccan campaigns, an unrelated theatre from the 1303 Delhi-facing Mongol emergency.

Trap: Merging separate Mongol episodes (1298, 1299, 1303, 1305) into one undifferentiated "Mongol invasion" event.

Workbook MCQ 07

Question: Which pair is correctly matched?

- A. Qutlugh Khwaja - Mabar campaign
- B. Malik Nayak - siege of Chittor
- C. Ali Beg and Tartaq - Amroha defeat
- D. Targhi - conquest of Gujarat

Answer: C - Ali Beg and Tartaq - Amroha defeat

- A. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Qutlugh Khwaja is linked to the 1299 Kili crisis near Delhi, not the far-southern Mabar campaign.
- B. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Malik Nayak is the commander credited with the 1305 Amroha victory over the Mongols, not the 1303 siege of Chittor.
- C. **Correct.** Correct. Ali Beg and Tartaq were the Mongol commanders defeated by Malik Nayak at Amroha in 1305, breaking the aura of Mongol invincibility.
- D. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Targhi is linked to the 1303 pressure on Delhi and Siri, not to the earlier Gujarat conquest of 1299.

Trap: Randomly cross-matching Mongol commanders, Delhi generals and campaigns that belong to different years and theatres.

Workbook MCQ 08

Question: In Alauddin's military administration, chehra refers to:

- A. a provincial iqta record
- B. a tax on grazing
- C. a branded horse-mark
- D. a descriptive roll of soldiers

Answer: D - a descriptive roll of soldiers

- A. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Iqta records concerned revenue assignment, an unrelated fiscal-administrative document from the army's own muster system.
- B. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Grazing tax (charai) is a separate agrarian levy from the doab reforms, not a military personnel record.
- C. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. A branded horse-mark is dagh, the paired but distinct instrument that checked horse substitution, not soldier identity.
- D. **Correct.** Correct. Chehra was the descriptive roll recording each soldier's identifying features, used to prevent fictitious musters and false salary claims.

Trap: Confusing chehra (soldier description) with dagh (horse branding) - the two paired but distinct army-inspection instruments.

Workbook MCQ 09

Question: Gujarat mattered to Alauddin above all because of its:

- A. ports, bullion and horse supply connections
- B. monastic universities only
- C. role as the Alai Minar's stone quarry
- D. frontier snow passes

Answer: A - ports, bullion and horse supply connections

- A. **Correct.** Correct. Gujarat's fertile wealth, western sea-ports and horse-trade significance are the reasons the sources emphasise for its 1299 conquest.
- B. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Monastic universities (such as those associated with Bihar/Bengal Buddhist learning) are unrelated to Gujarat's role in Khalji strategy.
- C. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. No source links Gujarat to supplying stone for the Alai Minar, which was built at Delhi using different resources and labour.
- D. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Gujarat is a western, coastal region; frontier snow passes belong to the north-western Mongol frontier, a different geography entirely.

Trap: Losing Gujarat's specific economic value (ports, bullion, horses) inside a vague "it was conquered" statement.

Workbook MCQ 10

Question: Ranthambore became a major Alauddin target partly because:

- A. it housed the Diwan-i-Riyasat
- B. Hamirdeva protected Mongol fugitives and defied Delhi
- C. Jalaluddin had already annexed it completely
- D. it was the main cloth market of the empire

Answer: B - Hamirdeva protected Mongol fugitives and defied Delhi

- A. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. The Diwan-i-Riyasat was Delhi's own market-regulation department, an urban fiscal institution with no connection to the Ranthambore fort.

- B. **Correct.** Correct. Hamirdeva's refusal to surrender Mongol fugitives, combined with the fort's strategic strength, made Ranthambore an urgent 1301 target.
- C. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Jalaluddin had not annexed Ranthambore; it remained an independent, resistant Rajput stronghold until Alauddin's 1301 siege.
- D. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. The cloth market (Sarai-i-Adl) was a Delhi urban institution, unrelated to a Rajasthan fort's strategic significance.

Trap: Missing the specific political trigger (sheltering Mongol fugitives) and substituting an unrelated institutional or geographic fact.

Workbook MCQ 11

Question: The safest statement about Chittor 1303 is that:

- A. no siege took place and the story is wholly fictitious
- B. the Padmavat narrative is a near-contemporary documentary account
- C. a secure siege-and-conquest event later acquired a powerful literary afterlife
- D. Khusrau wrote only about Padmavati and not about conquest

Answer: C - a secure siege-and-conquest event later acquired a powerful literary afterlife

- A. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. The siege and conquest of Chittor in 1303 is securely attested through near-contemporary courtly evidence, especially Amir Khusrau.
- B. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Padmavat was composed by Malik Muhammad Jaisi only in the sixteenth century, roughly two centuries after the event - it is not near-contemporary.
- C. **Correct.** Correct. This keeps the secure military event and its later literary elaboration as two distinct, both-important evidentiary layers.
- D. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Khusrau's near-contemporary account covers the siege and conquest but never mentions Padmini; the later legend is Jaisi's addition, not Khusrau's silence about conquest.

Trap: Either dismissing Chittor's siege as fiction or treating Padmavat as eyewitness history - both errors collapse two separate evidentiary layers.

Workbook MCQ 12

Question: Malwa under the Khaljis is best described as:

- A. only a tribute-paying Rajput state without direct intervention
- B. a purely symbolic claim in court poetry
- C. a zone never touched by Delhi power
- D. more directly brought under Delhi administration than many Rajput states

Answer: D - more directly brought under Delhi administration than many Rajput states

- A. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. "Tribute-paying without direct intervention" understates Malwa's position; it saw stronger, more direct Delhi control than typical tributary Rajput states.
- B. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Malwa's incorporation rests on the same campaign-and-administration evidence used for other zones, not on poetic claim alone.
- C. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Malwa was very much touched by Delhi power, being one of the clearer cases of stronger political incorporation under Alauddin.
- D. **Correct.** Correct. Compared with many Rajput states left as tribute-bearing subordinates, Malwa was brought under more direct Delhi administration.

Trap: Placing Malwa in the loosest tribute-only category when the evidence shows a more directly incorporated status.

Workbook MCQ 13

Question: Ramachandra of Devagiri is important because he:

- A. was restored as a subordinate ally and became useful for later Deccan policy
- B. permanently expelled Delhi from the south
- C. wrote the Tarikh-i Firuz Shahi
- D. built the Alai Darwaza

Answer: A - was restored as a subordinate ally and became useful for later Deccan policy

- A. **Correct.** Correct. Ramachandra's restoration as a subordinate ally after submission shows that Delhi sometimes preferred cooperative subordination over immediate annexation.
- B. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Ramachandra submitted to and cooperated with Delhi; he did not expel Delhi's influence from the Deccan, which continued through tribute and later campaigns.
- C. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. The Tarikh-i Firuz Shahi is Ziauddin Barani's chronicle, an entirely different, Delhi-based Persian source unrelated to the Devagiri ruler.
- D. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. The Alai Darwaza is a Delhi monument built under Alauddin's own patronage, with no connection to Ramachandra of Devagiri.

Trap: Assuming every conquered ruler was either fully expelled or fully annexed, missing the restored-subordinate-ally category.

Workbook MCQ 14

Question: Warangal under Alauddin is best characterised as:

- A. identical in status to the upper doab khalisa zone
- B. a theatre of submission and tribute before later annexation under the Tughlaqs
- C. outside all Khalji military concern
- D. an unquestioned Delhi province from the start

Answer: B - a theatre of submission and tribute before later annexation under the Tughlaqs

- A. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. The khalisa zone was directly taxed crown land under measurement-based revenue; Warangal under Alauddin was a tribute-paying, not directly administered, territory.
- B. **Correct.** Correct. Warangal submitted and paid tribute under Alauddin's campaigns, with fuller annexation belonging mainly to the later Tughlaq phase.
- C. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Warangal was very much a target of Khalji military concern, receiving repeated expeditions under Malik Kafur.
- D. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Warangal was not an administered Delhi province under Alauddin at all; it remained a tributary relationship in this period.

Trap: Backdating the Tughlaq-era annexation of Warangal into Alauddin's own reign, or denying Khalji interest in it altogether.

Workbook MCQ 15

Question: The main political purpose of the ban on elite banquets and marriage alliances was to:

- A. increase temple revenues
- B. replace horses with elephants
- C. break aristocratic coalition-building
- D. encourage Sufi egalitarianism

Answer: C - break aristocratic coalition-building

- A. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Temple revenue is an unrelated fiscal category from the specifically anti-conspiracy ordinances targeting noble social life.

- B. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Cavalry (dagh/chehra reforms) remained central to Khalji military policy; no source links these ordinances to a horse-to-elephant substitution.
- C. **Correct.** Correct. Restricting banquets, festive gatherings and unauthorised marriage alliances removed the social spaces where noble factions could coordinate rebellion.
- D. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. These ordinances were reason-of-state political controls on the nobility, not a religious or Sufi egalitarian programme.

Trap: Reading anti-rebellion social restrictions as either fiscal, military-equipment or religious measures instead of anti-conspiracy politics.

Workbook MCQ 16

Question: Which statement about Alauddin's reported confiscations is most accurate?

- A. They were merely a poetic metaphor.
- B. They were irrelevant to noble politics.
- C. They abolished all land grants in every province forever.
- D. They sought to deny nobles the wealth needed for autonomous rebellion.

Answer: D - They sought to deny nobles the wealth needed for autonomous rebellion.

- A. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Confiscation is reported as an actual administrative-political measure by Barani, not a figure of speech.
- B. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Confiscation is central to noble politics here - it is one of the four linked anti-rebellion measures alongside surveillance and social restriction.
- C. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Confiscation targeted suspicious accumulations of wealth and grants selectively, not a permanent, universal abolition of all land grants everywhere.
- D. **Correct.** Correct. Confiscation and surveillance worked together to deny nobles the independent financial resources an autonomous rebellion would require.

Trap: Treating confiscation as either non-political rhetoric or as a total, permanent land-grant abolition instead of a targeted anti-rebellion tool.

Workbook MCQ 17

Question: In the revenue system of Topic 04, khalisa most directly means:

- A. land whose revenue flowed directly to the imperial treasury
- B. a cash salary scale
- C. temple-free land only
- D. a village committee

Answer: A - land whose revenue flowed directly to the imperial treasury

- A. **Correct.** Correct. Khalisa land yielded its revenue directly to the state treasury rather than through an iqta assignment, which is why the upper doab's khalisa status mattered so much to Delhi.
- B. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. The cash salary scale (such as the reported 238 tankas for a cavalryman) is a separate concept from khalisa, which concerns land-revenue status.
- C. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Khalisa carries no religious connotation about temple land; it is a purely fiscal-administrative category of direct crown revenue.
- D. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. No village-committee institution is described in this topic; khalisa refers to a revenue-collection arrangement, not a local governance body.

Trap: Confusing khalisa's fiscal meaning (direct crown revenue) with unrelated salary, religious or village-governance concepts.

Workbook MCQ 18

Question: Which rural groups are specifically targeted in the source tradition as privileged intermediaries?

- A. Multani traders
- B. khuts, muqaddams and chaudhuris
- C. Chishti saints
- D. qazis and muftis

Answer: B - khuts, muqaddams and chaudhuris

- A. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Multani traders were urban/commercial merchants involved in the cloth trade, not rural land-revenue intermediaries.
- B. **Correct.** Correct. Khuts, muqaddams and chaudhuris are the classic rural-intermediary trio whose privileges Alauddin's revenue reform curtailed.
- C. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Chishti saints belong to the Sufi religious sphere, a separate topic from rural fiscal intermediaries.
- D. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Qazis and muftis are Islamic legal officials, unrelated to the specific rural revenue-intermediary groups this reform targeted.

Trap: Substituting an unrelated commercial, religious or legal group for the specific rural-intermediary trio the reform actually targeted.

Workbook MCQ 19

Question: The best reason to avoid calling Alauddin's price policy "socialism" is that it:

- A. arose from nineteenth-century social theory
- B. eliminated all market exchange
- C. was aimed chiefly at funding and disciplining a large cavalry under frontier pressure
- D. guaranteed equal welfare to all cultivators

Answer: C - was aimed chiefly at funding and disciplining a large cavalry under frontier pressure

- A. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. While the anachronism argument (socialism postdates the Khaljis) is true, it is not the best evidence-based reason - the deeper reason is the policy's actual military-fiscal purpose.
- B. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. The reforms regulated and channelled commerce (state advances to traders, registered banjaras) rather than eliminating market exchange altogether.
- C. **Correct.** Correct. The regime's core logic was funding and disciplining a large cavalry against Mongol pressure, not redistributive welfare ideology.
- D. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Far from guaranteeing cultivator welfare, the doab's half-produce demand and curtailed intermediaries placed severe burdens on rural society.

Trap: Picking a true but weaker anachronism argument instead of the stronger, evidence-based military-fiscal purpose as the reason to reject "socialism".

Workbook MCQ 20

Question: Which institutional cluster most clearly belongs to market regulation?

- A. Chihalgani, paibos, sijda and caliphal investiture
- B. Mansabdars, zat and sawar
- C. zabt, patta and qabauliyat
- D. Shahna-i-Mandi, merchant registers, banjaras and state granaries

Answer: D - Shahna-i-Mandi, merchant registers, banjaras and state granaries

- A. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Chihalgani, paibos, sijda and caliphal investiture belong to Mamluk-era court ceremony and elite institution-building (Topic 03), not Khalji market regulation.

- B. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Mansabdars, zat and sawar are Mughal administrative-military ranking terms, centuries later than the Khalji market system.
- C. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Zabt, patta and qabauliyat belong to later Mughal revenue administration (notably Akbar's system), not Alauddin's market institutions.
- D. **Correct.** Correct. Shahna-i-Mandi, merchant registers, banjaras and state granaries are precisely the linked regulatory nodes of Alauddin's Delhi market system.

Trap: Importing terminology from a different dynasty or century (Mamluk court ritual, Mughal administration) into a Khalji-specific institutional question.

Workbook MCQ 21

Question: Sample prices such as wheat at 7 1/2 jitals per man are best used as:

- A. reported schedule markers from Barani via Satish Chandra, with unit caution
- B. official audited statistics from a modern revenue department
- C. evidence that merchants disappeared from Delhi
- D. proof of uniform prices across every province and year

Answer: A - reported schedule markers from Barani via Satish Chandra, with unit caution

- A. **Correct.** Correct. These figures survive only through Barani as transmitted by Satish Chandra, so they should be cited as illustrative markers with a unit/manuscript caveat, not certified statistics.
- B. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. No modern-style audited revenue department existed in the Khalji Sultanate; the figures come from a normative chronicle, not an administrative dataset.
- C. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. The price schedule presupposes active merchants operating under regulation; it is not evidence of commerce's disappearance.
- D. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. The strongest evidence for these prices is Delhi-centred; extending them as proof of uniform empire-wide, all-year prices overstates the source's reach.

Trap: Treating a Barani-reported price figure as a certified, uniform, empire-wide statistic rather than a cautioned illustrative marker.

Workbook MCQ 22

Question: The grain-granary-banjara system mattered because it:

- A. removed the need for cavalry pay
- B. connected field extraction to capital provisioning under supervision
- C. replaced all local mandis
- D. ended the use of cash in the countryside

Answer: B - connected field extraction to capital provisioning under supervision

- A. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. The system existed precisely to make cavalry pay affordable by keeping grain prices low in Delhi, not to remove the need for pay itself.
- B. **Correct.** Correct. The chain connected doab field extraction to Delhi's capital provisioning through registered, supervised banjara transport and granary storage.
- C. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Part I's own OCR notes some cultivators still sold directly to local mandis, so local markets were not wholly replaced.
- D. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Cash demand was integral to the reform - cultivators were pushed toward cash-linked grain sale, not away from cash use.

Trap: Overstating the system's reach (ending cash, replacing all local markets) instead of describing its actual function as a supervised supply chain.

Workbook MCQ 23

Question: Which statement best captures the relation between market control and commerce?

- A. Merchants ceased to exist in Gujarat and Delhi.
- B. Trade became irrelevant once grain was stored.
- C. The system regulated and channelled commerce rather than eliminating it.
- D. Alauddin abolished merchants and trade itself.

Answer: C - The system regulated and channelled commerce rather than eliminating it.

- A. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Gujarat's ports and Delhi's cloth market both depended on continuing merchant activity; merchants did not disappear.
- B. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Grain storage (granaries) was one component among many; it did not make ongoing merchant trade in cloth, horses or other goods irrelevant.
- C. **Correct.** Correct. State advances to traders, registered banjaras and continued cloth-market growth show commerce being disciplined and redirected, not eliminated.
- D. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. This directly contradicts the evidence of state advances to Multani traders and Delhi becoming the biggest fine-cloth market.

Trap: Reading strict regulation as total abolition of trade, when the evidence shows disciplined, continuing commerce.

Workbook MCQ 24

Question: One lasting economic significance attributed to Alauddin's agrarian reforms in Part I is:

- A. the end of all village markets
- B. the destruction of the town-country relationship
- C. complete equality in rural society
- D. the furthering of a market economy and tighter town-country linkage

Answer: D - the furthering of a market economy and tighter town-country linkage

- A. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Part I's OCR credits the reforms with furthering village market growth, the opposite of ending village markets.
- B. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. The reforms are credited with a more integral town-country relationship, not its destruction.
- C. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Heavy revenue extraction and curtailed intermediary privilege increased pressure on cultivators; this is not evidence of rural equality.
- D. **Correct.** Correct. Satish Chandra's Part I explicitly credits the agrarian reforms with furthering village market growth and a tighter town-country linkage.

Trap: Assuming heavy state extraction must have destroyed rural commerce, when the sources credit it with expanding monetised market activity.

Workbook MCQ 25

Question: Alauddin's reported stance on shara is best read as:

- A. a reason-of-state position that qualified juristic neatness without making him a modern secular ruler
- B. proof that the ulema fully ruled the state
- C. evidence that religion was irrelevant to the Sultanate
- D. a direct constitutional theory of secular citizenship

Answer: A - a reason-of-state position that qualified juristic neatness without making him a modern secular ruler

- A. **Correct.** Correct. Barani's reported argument shows Alauddin prioritising state necessity over strict juristic conformity, a reason-of-state stance distinct from both theocracy and modern secularism.

- B. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. The whole point of the reported dialogue is that political decisions could override strict juristic preference, contradicting full ulema rule.
- C. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Alauddin still used Islamic legitimation and religious rhetoric; religion was not simply irrelevant to his statecraft.
- D. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. "Constitutional secular citizenship" is an anachronistic modern legal-political concept with no basis in the medieval reason-of-state idiom described here.

Trap: Forcing a medieval reason-of-state stance into either a modern secular-constitutional label or a pure-theocracy label.

Workbook MCQ 26

Question: Which monument is most directly tied to Alauddin's unfinished imperial ambition?

- A. Quwwat-ul-Islam mosque
- B. Alai Minar
- C. Sultan Ghari
- D. Tughlaqabad

Answer: B - Alai Minar

- A. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. The Quwwat-ul-Islam mosque belongs to the earlier Mamluk-era Qutb complex under Aibak and Iltutmish, not to Alauddin's own ambitious, unfinished projects.
- B. **Correct.** Correct. The Alai Minar was begun at twice the Qutb Minar's height but left incomplete, making it the clearest architectural expression of unfinished Khalji ambition.
- C. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Sultan Ghari is an earlier Mamluk-period tomb, unconnected to Alauddin's own building programme.
- D. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Tughlaqabad was built under the succeeding Tughlaq dynasty, after the Khalji period this topic covers had already ended.

Trap: Mismatching a Mamluk-era or Tughlaq-era monument with a question specifically about Alauddin's own unfinished ambition.

Workbook MCQ 27

Question: The safest statement about Hauz-i-Alai / Hauz Khas is:

- A. it was wholly unrelated to Alauddin
- B. it was a Mongol frontier fort
- C. the reservoir is linked to Alauddin, while Firuz later built around the site
- D. it was built by Akbar as a market reservoir

Answer: C - the reservoir is linked to Alauddin, while Firuz later built around the site

- A. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. The reservoir itself is directly linked to Alauddin as Hauz-i-Alai, so "wholly unrelated" is factually wrong.
- B. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Hauz-i-Alai was an urban water-supply reservoir near Delhi, not a Mongol-frontier military fort.
- C. **Correct.** Correct. Alauddin built the original reservoir, while Firuz Tughlaq later added a madrasa and pleasure complex around the same site, so both phases must be kept distinct.
- D. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Akbar reigned over two centuries later under the Mughals and has no building association with this Delhi Sultanate-era reservoir.

Trap: Collapsing two separate building phases (Alauddin's reservoir, Firuz's later additions) into one ruler, or misdating the site to the Mughals.

Workbook MCQ 28

Question: Which source is contemporary but also overtly court-panegyrical for Khalji campaigns?

- A. Barani's Fatawa-i Jahandari
- B. Ibn Battuta
- C. Abul Fazl
- D. Amir Khusrau's campaign writing

Answer: D - Amir Khusrau's campaign writing

- A. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Barani's Fatawa-i Jahandari is a normative political-theory text, not primarily a campaign narrative, and Barani himself writes decades later, not contemporaneously.
- B. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Ibn Battuta travelled and wrote under Muhammad bin Tughlaq, a full generation after the Khalji campaigns this question asks about.
- C. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Abul Fazl is Akbar's Mughal-era chronicler, writing nearly three centuries after the Khalji age.
- D. **Correct.** Correct. Amir Khusrau wrote as a contemporary court poet whose campaign narratives (such as Khaza'in-ul-Futuh) are simultaneously valuable and overtly panegyrical.

Trap: Picking a source from the wrong century (Ibn Battuta, Abul Fazl) instead of the genuinely contemporary but panegyrical Amir Khusrau.

Workbook MCQ 29

Question: Malik Kafur's post-1316 importance lies chiefly in the fact that he:

- A. became vice-regent and intervened decisively in succession politics
- B. restored Jalaluddin to the throne
- C. led the first Mongol invasion of India
- D. founded the Tughlaq dynasty

Answer: A - became vice-regent and intervened decisively in succession politics

- A. **Correct.** Correct. As malik naib/vice-regent, Kafur elevated a minor heir and moved against rivals after Alauddin's death, directly shaping the succession crisis before his own killing.
- B. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Jalaluddin had already been murdered in 1296, two decades before 1316; he could not be restored to a throne he no longer held.
- C. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Mongol invasions predate Kafur's career and belong to Alauddin's own frontier defence, not to Kafur's post-1316 role.
- D. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Ghazi Malik (Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq) founded the Tughlaq dynasty in 1320, after defeating Khusrau Khan, not Malik Kafur.

Trap: Confusing Malik Kafur's succession-crisis role with unrelated events belonging to Jalaluddin, the Mongols or the eventual Tughlaq founder.

Workbook MCQ 30

Question: Qutbuddin Mubarak Shah is especially remembered in Topic 04 because he:

- A. wrote Padmavat
- B. abolished many of Alauddin's agrarian and market controls to gain support
- C. permanently reunited all Deccan kingdoms with Delhi
- D. restored many of the earlier controls and tightened market regulation still further

Answer: B - abolished many of Alauddin's agrarian and market controls to gain support

- A. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Padmavat was written by Malik Muhammad Jaisi in the sixteenth century, two centuries after Mubarak Shah's brief reign.

- B. **Correct.** Correct. Mubarak Shah reversed many of Alauddin's agrarian and market controls in order to win support, showing how ruler-dependent the system had been.
- C. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. No source credits Mubarak Shah with a permanent, comprehensive reunification of the Deccan; Deccan control remained partial and contested.
- D. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. This is the reverse of what the sources report - he relaxed and reversed controls, he did not tighten or restore them further.

Trap: Reversing the actual direction of Mubarak Shah's policy (relaxation, not intensification) or attributing an unrelated later text to him.

Workbook MCQ 31

Question: Historiographically, the most useful role of K. S. Lal-type readings in Topic 04 is to:

- A. prove that Barani is unnecessary
- B. establish Padmavat as contemporary archive
- C. remind us of the regime's coercive depth, while still qualifying total-control claims
- D. deny all military logic to the reforms

Answer: C - remind us of the regime's coercive depth, while still qualifying total-control claims

- A. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Centralisation-heavy readings still rely on Barani as their primary evidentiary base; they do not make Barani unnecessary.
- B. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Padmavat's contemporary status is a separate source-criticism question unrelated to the K. S. Lal-type centralisation debate.
- C. **Correct.** Correct. These readings usefully foreground the depth of Khalji coercion, but their claims of totality still need the scope caution this topic insists on.
- D. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Centralisation-heavy readings, if anything, emphasise military-coercive logic more strongly, not less.

Trap: Treating a historiographical school as either irrelevant or as settling the debate outright, instead of weighing its specific contribution and limit.

Workbook MCQ 32

Question: The best concluding line for Topic 04 is that the Khalji phase:

- A. mattered only for architecture and nothing else
- B. was simply a literary myth
- C. ended all later institutional continuity in the Sultanate
- D. combined major military-fiscal experimentation with impressive but ruler-dependent coercive institutions

Answer: D - combined major military-fiscal experimentation with impressive but ruler-dependent coercive institutions

- A. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Architecture (Siri, Alai Darwaza) is only one dimension; the topic's core significance lies in political, military and fiscal state-building.
- B. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Barani, Khusrau, inscriptions, coins and monuments together secure the Khalji period as historical, not merely literary myth.
- C. **Incorrect.** Incorrect. Delhi, iqta logic and army routines carried over into the Tughlaq order; institutional continuity, not total rupture, followed 1320.
- D. **Correct.** Correct. This captures both the achievement (major military-fiscal experimentation) and the fragility (ruler-dependent coercive institutions) in one graded verdict.

Trap: Choosing a one-sided verdict (only architecture, only myth, total rupture) instead of the balanced achievement-and-fragility conclusion the topic requires.

Remediation map - predictable errors and their correcting Workbook MCQs

Predictable error	Corrected by
Reading the Khalji period through an ideological label (socialist, communal, purely literary)	Workbook MCQ 01, 19
Treating "Khalji revolution" as a social or agrarian revolution rather than elite recomposition	Workbook MCQ 02
Flattening the Jalaluddin/Alauddin contrast or the manner of Alauddin's 1296 seizure	Workbook MCQ 03, 04
Merging separate Mongol episodes (1298, 1299, 1303, 1305) into one undifferentiated invasion	Workbook MCQ 06, 07
Confusing dagh (horse branding) with chehra (soldier roll)	Workbook MCQ 08
Assuming every campaign (Gujarat, Ranthambore, Chittor, Malwa, Deccan) produced the same kind of control	Workbook MCQ 05, 09, 10, 12, 13, 14
Treating Padmavat as contemporary Chittor evidence instead of sixteenth-century literary memory	Workbook MCQ 11
Misreading anti-rebellion ordinances as religious, fiscal or unrelated to noble-conspiracy control	Workbook MCQ 15, 16
Confusing khalisa, rural-intermediary and market-institution terminology with later Mughal terms	Workbook MCQ 17, 18, 20
Treating Barani-reported prices or the price schedule as certified, uniform, empire-wide statistics	Workbook MCQ 21
Overstating market control as ending trade, cash use or local mandis rather than disciplining commerce	Workbook MCQ 22, 23, 24
Forcing Alauddin's reason-of-state stance into modern secularism or pure theocracy	Workbook MCQ 25
Misattributing a monument or building phase to the wrong ruler or century	Workbook MCQ 26, 27
Citing a source from the wrong century instead of a genuinely contemporary but biased chronicler	Workbook MCQ 28
Confusing Malik Kafur's, Mubarak Shah's and the Tughlaq founder's roles in the 1316-1320 succession crisis	Workbook MCQ 29, 30
Treating one historiographical school as either irrelevant or as settling the whole debate	Workbook MCQ 31
Ending on a one-sided verdict instead of the balanced achievement-and-fragility conclusion	Workbook MCQ 32

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Verified and routed PYQs

Direct PYQ 01 - UPSC Prelims 2022 GS-I (direct routed question; exact wording verified locally; official key unavailable locally)

Question: With reference to Indian history, consider the following statements:

1. The first Mongol invasion of India happened during the reign of Jalal-ud-din Khalji.
2. During the reign of Ala-ud-din Khalji, one Mongol assault marched up to Delhi and besieged the city.
3. Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq temporarily lost portions of north-west of his kingdom to Mongols.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 (b) 2 only (c) 1 and 3 (d) 3 only

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: (b) 2 only. Confidence: high.

Model explanation: Statement 1 is incorrect because Mongol pressure and penetration into the north-west predated Jalaluddin Khalji; Topic 03 already anchored pressure in Iltutmish's age and the later Lahore sack. Statement 2 is correct because the **1303 Targhi crisis** brought Mongol pressure up to Delhi and Alauddin's defended Siri position. Statement 3 is unsafe in the wording used and is treated as incorrect in this repository's validated Topic 03 explanation; Muhammad bin Tughlaq had frontier problems and diplomacy, but the statement as framed is not the standard established event.

Why this earns marks: It fixes the chronology by ruler, separates frontier pressure from the Delhi siege crisis and refuses to validate a statement only because it mentions a familiar Tughlaq name.

Demand decoding: This is a three-statement elimination question that names three different rulers (Jalaluddin, Alauddin, Muhammad bin Tughlaq); each statement must be checked against its own ruler's chronology rather than treated as one generic claim about "Mongol invasions."

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Eliminate statement 1 first by naming that Mongol pressure on the north-west predates Jalaluddin (already anchored in Iltutmish's reign); confirm statement 2 by naming the 1303 Targhi crisis and Alauddin's defended Siri position; treat statement 3 cautiously since the framed wording does not match this repository's validated Tughlaq-era event; conclude with option (b).

How to improve this answer: Add the specific year (1303) and commander (Targhi) for statement 2 rather than a vague "Mongols besieged Delhi" claim, since UPSC statement-based questions reward exact chronology over generic recognition.

Adjacent PYQ 02 - UPSC GS-I 2020 (verified adjacent source question; primary routing elsewhere, but directly valuable for Topic 04 source criticism)

Question: Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

Persian literary sources are indispensable for medieval India because they preserve the political language, moral anxieties and courtly horizons of the age. Yet they reflect the spirit of the age only if used with **genre and patronage caution**.

The strongest evidence lies in the Sultanate archive. **Ziauddin Barani's** *Tarikh-i Firuz Shahi* records rulers, nobles, market regulations and ideas of order from Balban to the Tughlaqs. For Topic 04, it is the key source for Alauddin Khalji's ordinances and price-control system. But Barani was a fourteenth-century aristocratic moralist; his hostility to the "low and ignoble" means that vivid numbers, motives and speeches need qualification.

Amir Khusrau's courtly works, including *Khaza'in-ul-Futuh*, illuminate conquest, ceremonial culture and Indo-Persian self-fashioning. His value for the Khalji age is enormous: Chittor, Gujarat and Deccan campaigns all pass through his courtly lens. Yet the same lens is panegyrical. He celebrates power better than he documents administrative limits or non-elite suffering.

At the same time, Persian sources widen beyond bare political narrative. They capture elite ideals, religious debate, urban sensibility and the moral language of sovereignty. Their silences are equally revealing: peasants, women outside elite circles and regional society appear unevenly.

Hence, Persian sources do reflect the spirit of the age - but the spirit they show is mediated, courtly and argumentative rather than neutral reportage. They are most powerful when read against inscriptions, monuments, coins and other narrative traditions.

Why this earns marks: The answer opens with a clear thesis, uses named sources from the Khalji age, links each source to what it proves, and qualifies each source instead of treating Persian writing as transparent fact.

Demand decoding: "Comment" asks for a direct evaluative position on whether Persian sources reflect the age's spirit, not a descriptive list of chronicles; the answer must name at least two sources, show what each proves, and state what each cannot prove.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Open with the qualified thesis (sources reflect the age, but through a courtly, argumentative lens); use Barani for policy and ordinances with his aristocratic bias flagged; use

Khusrau for campaign atmosphere with his panegyric patronage flagged; close by naming the archive's silence on peasants and non-elite voices.

How to improve this answer: Add Isami as a third named source to show the retrospective, Deccan-transition angle, since citing only two chroniclers leaves the "spirit of the age" claim resting on a narrower base than the topic actually supports.

Adjacent PYQ 03 - UPSC GS-I 2023 (verified adjacent Sultanate question; primary routing to broader administration/technology owners)

Question: What were the major technological changes introduced during the Sultanate period? How did those technological changes influence the Indian society? (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

The Sultanate period did not invent technology from nothing, but it accelerated the diffusion and combination of several techniques in textiles, construction, cavalry management and irrigation. Their effects were strongest in **state capacity, urban life and long-distance exchange**.

In construction, the widespread use of the **true arch, dome and stronger lime mortar** transformed scale and skyline. Topic 04's Khalji phase is crucial here: **Alai Darwaza** marks mature scientific arch-and-dome construction, while **Siri** shows how military pressure could produce new defended urban forms. The impact was not merely aesthetic. Larger covered spaces, gateways and fortified capitals supported royal ceremonial and political control.

In military organisation, improved cavalry inspection through **dagh** and **chehra** under Alauddin Khalji shows technology as administration. Branding horses and maintaining descriptive rolls reduced fraud and preserved army efficiency under Mongol pressure.

In textiles and circulation, the broader Sultanate period saw wider use of the **spinning wheel**, the **cotton-carder's bow**, improved looms and market-linked craft production. This supported urban growth, merchant activity and the provisioning systems on which capitals depended.

The social effect, however, was uneven. These changes strengthened towns, armies, merchants and courts more than they emancipated cultivators. Monumental construction and military inspection served states before they served social equality.

Therefore, Sultanate technological change mattered profoundly, but its historical meaning lies in the interaction of technique with political power, urbanisation and unequal social structure.

Why this earns marks: It answers both parts of the question, uses precise Khalji-era examples, and converts technology into social and political consequences rather than listing devices mechanically.

Demand decoding: The question has two explicit parts - "what changed" and "how did it influence society" - so a one-part answer listing only techniques without their social effect loses half the available marks.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: List construction (true arch, dome, mortar), military-administrative (dagh, chehra) and textile/craft changes as the "what"; then dedicate the closing third of the answer explicitly to the "how", naming that these changes strengthened states, armies, merchants and courts more than they emancipated cultivators.

How to improve this answer: Add one concrete building example beyond Alai Darwaza and Siri (such as a specific textile or irrigation technique named in the sources) to avoid over-relying on Khalji architecture alone for a Sultanate-wide question.

Original solved Mains practice

10-mark Question 01

Question: Was the Khalji "revolution" more a reconfiguration of the ruling class than a social revolution? Discuss. (Answer in 150 words)

Model solution:

Yes - in UPSC-safe usage the Khalji "revolution" is better understood as a **reconfiguration of elite access** than as a social revolution.

First, the local Satish Chandra evidence stresses that the rise of Jalaluddin Khalji ended the old Turkish monopoly of high office. Khaljis, Indian Muslims and other non-monopoly groups gained greater room in the ruling class. This is the strongest positive content of the phrase.

Second, the institutional structure remained recognisably Sultanate. Delhi stayed the centre, iqta logic continued, coercive monarchy persisted, and countryside hierarchy was not democratised. Alauddin's later regime was if anything harsher and more centralised than before.

Third, the population at large did not experience a social levelling revolution. Peasants still faced heavy extraction; nobles still dominated; military slavery and court hierarchy persisted.

Thus, the term is useful only when limited to **ruling-class composition and political access**. It becomes misleading when stretched into a mass social transformation.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, uses Satish Chandra's core insight, distinguishes elite from society and ends with a graded verdict.

Demand decoding: "Discuss" requires taking a clear side on the reconfiguration-versus-revolution question within 150 words, not a neutral summary of both possible readings.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: State the verdict (reconfiguration, not revolution) in the opening line; support it with the ended Turkish monopoly of high office as positive evidence; balance it with continued Delhi-centred institutions and unchanged peasant condition as the limiting evidence; close in one line.

How to improve this answer: Name Malik Kafur specifically as an example of the widened elite Alauddin himself promoted, since a concrete post-1296 example strengthens the "reconfiguration" claim beyond the 1290 accession alone.

10-mark Question 02

Question: How did Mongol pressure reshape Alauddin Khalji's state? Explain. (Answer in 150 words)

Model solution:

Mongol pressure pushed Alauddin Khalji toward a far more integrated **military-fiscal state**.

First, repeated crises - especially the 1299 Kili episode, the 1303 Siri-Delhi pressure and the 1305 Amroha battle - demonstrated that Delhi needed a large and ready cavalry. These events are securely anchored in the local OCR and PYQ routing.

Second, that army required affordable horses, reliable pay and fortified frontiers. Alauddin therefore strengthened the cavalry through **dagh** and **chehra**, repaired frontier forts and used a defended urban space at **Siri**.

Third, the fiscal base had to be deepened. Heavy revenue demand in the doab, cash realisation, grain movement and fixed prices all helped preserve the real value of soldier salaries.

Hence Mongol pressure did not produce only military response; it drove revenue reform, price regulation, surveillance and urban provisioning as well.

Why this earns marks: It converts frontier danger into an institutional chain rather than narrating battles in isolation.

Demand decoding: "Explain" wants the causal mechanism linking Mongol pressure to state reform, not a battle-by-battle narrative of 1299-1305.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Open with the three named crises (1299 Kili, 1303 Siri-Delhi, 1305 Amroha) as the trigger; move directly to army reform (dagh, chehra, forts); close with the fiscal chain (doab revenue, grain movement, fixed prices) that made the army affordable.

How to improve this answer: Add the reported 238-tanka cavalry pay figure with its unit caveat, since a named number anchors the "affordability" claim more precisely than a general statement about cheap provisions.

15-mark Question 01

Question: Examine Alauddin Khalji's market regulations as an integrated military-fiscal system. (Answer in 250 words)

Model solution:

Alauddin Khalji's market regulations are best explained not as welfare economics, but as a **Delhi-centred military-fiscal system**.

The starting point was strategic necessity. The Mongol attacks of the late 1290s and early 1300s convinced Alauddin that Delhi needed a large standing cavalry. Yet a large cavalry implied recurring expenditure on soldiers, horses and urban provisioning. The state therefore sought not merely treasure, but a durable mechanism for keeping the **real cost** of cavalry manageable.

This is where agrarian policy and market policy converged. In the upper doab, land revenue was pushed toward **half of the produce**, khalisa control was strengthened, measurement was used where supported, and cultivators were drawn into cash-linked grain sale. Grain then moved through monitored channels - banjaras, mandis and granaries - into Delhi. On the urban side, the grain mandi, the cloth sphere, and the horse-cattle-slave market were supervised by the **Shahna-i-Mandi** and linked to the wider regulatory authority of the **Diwan-i-Riyasat**.

The result was a chain: **revenue extraction -> supply control -> regulated prices -> affordable cash salaries -> military sustainability**. Barani's sample prices, and the reported cavalry pay scale of roughly 238 tankas annually, make sense within this chain.

Yet the system had limits. It depended on coercion, intelligence, capital-city concentration and ruler-driven discipline. Its strongest evidence is Delhi-centric, and it frayed quickly after Alauddin's death.

Thus, the regulations were integrated, innovative and effective in context, but narrow in geography and fragile in durability.

Why this earns marks: The answer uses the required mechanism, names the offices, links rural and urban policy, and finishes with scope and durability limits.

Demand decoding: "Examine" wants the internal mechanism of the market system laid out step by step, not a list of institutions without their causal links.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Open with the Mongol-necessity thesis; trace the chain from doab revenue and khalisa control through banjara/granary transport to the Shahna-i-Mandi and Diwan-i-Riyasat's urban enforcement; close with the Delhi-centred, coercion-dependent limit.

How to improve this answer: Name at least one sample Barani-reported price (such as wheat at 7 1/2 jitals per man) with its unit caveat to show precise command of the evidence rather than describing the system only in institutional terms.

15-mark Question 02

Question: Distinguish the secure political-military evidence on Chittor from the later Padmavat tradition. (Answer in 250 words)

Model solution:

The 1303 Chittor episode must be read through **source layering**.

The secure first layer is the political-military event. Near-contemporary courtly evidence, especially Amir Khusrau, anchors the siege, Alauddin's campaign context and the Khalji victory. The event fits the wider Rajputana strategy after Gujarat and Ranthambore. Chittor mattered strategically, not only symbolically.

The second layer consists of conquest rhetoric. Khusrau's world is a court-praised world. Massacre motifs, triumphal language and the silence on uncomfortable details must be read as part of panegyric, not as transparent field-reporting.

The third layer is later literary memory. The **Padmavat** tradition associated with Malik Muhammad Jaisi is much later. It transforms the historical siege into a Sufi-inflected romance of beauty, desire, kingship and honour. Its narrative

power is immense, but it is not a simple documentary source for 1303.

Hence, the historian must separate three things: the secure siege, the courtly rhetorical framing of conquest, and the later symbolic afterlife in Rajput and Indo-Persian memory. The error lies not in studying Padmavat, but in using it unfiltered as if it were contemporary evidence.

A good UPSC answer therefore says: **Chittor 1303 is historically secure; Padmavat is historically important as later memory, not as straightforward eyewitness archive.**

Why this earns marks: It uses named evidence, honours literary significance without surrendering chronology, and shows exactly how source criticism operates.

Demand decoding: "Distinguish" requires a structured two-layer comparison (secure event versus later legend), not a single continuous narrative that blends both.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Open by naming Khusrau as the near-contemporary anchor for the siege; add the courtly-panegyric caveat on his conquest rhetoric as a second layer; introduce Jaisi's sixteenth-century Padmavat as the third, clearly later layer; close with the verdict that both layers matter but answer different questions.

How to improve this answer: Add the two-century gap explicitly (1303 to Jaisi's sixteenth-century composition) as a numeric anchor, since naming the actual time gap is more persuasive than simply asserting that Padmavat is "later" without a number.

20-mark Question 01

Question: "Alauddin Khalji's price control was neither socialism nor mere anti-merchant tyranny, but a Delhi-centred military-fiscal experiment." Critically evaluate. (Answer in 250 words)

Model solution:

The statement is broadly valid because Alauddin Khalji's price control makes the most sense as a **military-fiscal experiment** rooted in frontier pressure, noble politics and capital provisioning.

The evidence begins with the Mongol crisis. The Delhi-facing attacks of 1299, 1303 and 1305 showed that the Sultanate required a large cavalry under continuous readiness. A large cavalry, however, could not be sustained by windfall plunder alone. The state therefore needed to reduce the **real cost** of military maintenance.

This aim explains the interlocking structure of the reforms. In the upper doab, revenue demand rose sharply, direct khalisa control expanded, and measurement was used where supported. The grain thus drawn into state-visible channels was pushed into Delhi through banjaras, mandis and monitored sale. In the capital, staple grain, costly cloth and horse-cattle-slave markets were supervised through registers, the Shahna-i-Mandi and punitive enforcement. The reported price schedules preserved the value of cash salaries. That is why the system was linked to cavalry inspection through **dagh** and **chehra**, not separate from them.

Yet it would still be wrong to describe the system as benign consumer policy. It rested on coercion, heavy extraction, surveillance and severe penalties. Nor was it simply anti-merchant. Merchants, especially in cloth and grain supply, remained necessary; some even received state advances. Commerce was disciplined, not abolished.

Finally, the system's limits are decisive. It was Delhi-centred, expensive to police, mediated by Barani's moralising narrative, and highly ruler-dependent. Its rapid weakening after 1316 shows that coercive brilliance had outrun institutional durability.

Therefore, Alauddin's market control was a remarkable but bounded military-fiscal solution - neither modern socialism nor irrational persecution of trade.

Why this earns marks: It directly addresses the quotation, uses named evidence, shows mechanism, rejects two false binaries, and closes with a balanced critical verdict.

Demand decoding: "Critically evaluate" a quoted thesis with two named false binaries (socialism, anti-merchant tyranny) means the answer must explicitly reject both alternatives with evidence, not merely restate the given quotation as a conclusion.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Open by accepting the quotation's thesis; build the Mongol-crisis-to-market-system causal chain as the main evidence body; explicitly refute "socialism" (coercion, not

welfare) and "anti-merchant tyranny" (traders received state advances) as the two named alternatives; close with the Delhi-centred, ruler-dependent limit.

How to improve this answer: Add the post-1316 collapse (Mubarak Shah's reversals) as direct evidence for the "bounded" and "not modern socialism" conclusion, since a system built for redistribution would not have been unwound for political convenience within a year of the ruler's death.

20-mark Question 02

Question: Assess the achievements and limits of the Khaljis in expansion, elite control and state formation. (Answer in 250 words)

Model solution:

The Khaljis mark one of the Sultanate's most consequential phases because they combined **elite reconfiguration**, **territorial expansion** and **deepened military-fiscal state formation**. But all three achievements carried serious limits.

Their first achievement was political. The accession of Jalaluddin Khalji ended the old Turkish monopoly of high office and widened the social base of the ruling class. This did not democratise society, but it changed who could rise within the Delhi political order. Alauddin deepened this by recruiting and promoting non-monopoly elements, including Malik Kafur and other non-Turkish figures.

Their second achievement was military and territorial. Gujarat, Ranthambore, Chittor and Malwa extended Delhi's reach in the west and centre. Deccan campaigns under Malik Kafur opened Devagiri, Warangal, Dwarasamudra and Mabar to Delhi's fiscal and political horizon. Yet the limits were sharp: Rajputana was not uniformly administered, and in the Deccan tribute, plunder and restored subordination often mattered more than direct rule.

Their third and greatest achievement was state formation under Alauddin. Confronting Mongol danger and noble conspiracy, he built a large cavalry, imposed **dagh** and **chehra**, tightened the doab revenue base, regulated markets and provisioned Delhi. This was a genuine military-fiscal innovation.

But the limits were built into the system. Heavy extraction, ruler-centred coercion, Delhi-focused enforcement and a fragile succession order meant that detailed controls did not long outlive Alauddin. Malik Kafur's interventions, Mubarak Shah's reversals and the fall to the Tughlaqs exposed that weakness.

Thus, the Khaljis achieved a major expansion and an extraordinary hardening of the Delhi state, but they did not solve the problem of durable, impersonal institutional continuity.

Why this earns marks: It is organised by the exact themes in the question, uses concrete examples in each theme, and ends with a graded verdict instead of a flat celebration.

Demand decoding: "Assess" three named dimensions (expansion, elite control, state formation) requires the answer to visibly organise itself by those three headings, each carrying its own achievement and its own limit, rather than one undifferentiated narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Take the three dimensions in the question's own order; for each, name one achievement (widened elite, Gujarat/Malwa/Deccan reach, dagh/chehra/market system) immediately followed by its specific limit (uneven Deccan control, coercion-dependence, ruler-dependent succession); close with the single graded verdict linking all three limits to the post-1316 collapse.

How to improve this answer: Add one explicit transition sentence connecting the three themes (wider elite staffed the harsher state, which financed the Deccan opening) so the three-part structure reads as one argument rather than three separate mini-essays.